

OXFORD

INTERNATIONAL
AQA EXAMINATIONS

INTERNATIONAL A-LEVEL PSYCHOLOGY

(9685) PS04 Paper 4

Report on the examination

June 2023

REPORT ON EXAMINATION: INTERNATIONAL A-LEVEL PSYCHOLOGY 9685 PS04 JUNE 2023

General Feedback

Performance on this exam was comparable with previous series in that most students were able to demonstrate good psychological knowledge and understanding. Overall, students performed better on questions requiring AO1 skills and found questions that required AO2 and AO3 skills more challenging. For AO2 questions, stronger responses went beyond the stem to provide effective explanations using psychological knowledge, whereas weaker responses tended to simply repeat the stem. Stronger students could also provide well developed evaluation which used theory or context to elaborate appropriate evaluation/discussion points.

Many students, however, still offer generic evaluation points that could apply to any explanation or study and do not achieve marks above level two. In addition, many students had difficulty spotting the word 'evaluate' in some of the short answer questions and offered description rather than evaluation. This meant that they failed to access any marks on such questions. Students would benefit from practice in identifying relevant theory/studies present in scenario-type questions before going on to use the theory/study identified to explain the behaviour. In addition, it might be useful for students to look at model answers alongside the level descriptors found in the mark schemes, to develop an understanding of what makes effective evaluation.

QUESTION 01.1

Most students did well on this question and could accurately identify 'vicarious reinforcement' as learning that involves observing the consequences of other peoples' actions.

QUESTION 01.2

This proved difficult for some with students often struggling to define the term 'mediational processes' and, instead, offering examples of mediational processes.

QUESTION 02

There was a pleasing performance on this comparison AO3 question with more than half the students providing a clear difference between two types of reinforcement. For example, they could state that positive reinforcement involves the provision of a reward to shape/obtain behaviour, whereas negative reinforcement works by the removal of an unpleasant stimulus to shape/obtain behaviour. Weaker responses offered a definition of two types of reinforcement without making a clear comparison between them. Overall, the ability to answer this type of question is improving.

QUESTION 03

This application question proved challenging with most students achieving only two of the four marks available. Many simply offered a description of the multi-store model of memory instead of using the model to explain how such concrete examples of unseen mental processes can help psychologists to understand internal mental processes. Stronger answers focussed on the way in which theoretical models can be used to represent, visualise, or test internal mental processes that cannot be seen and used the features of the multistore model to illustrate their answer.

QUESTION 04.1

This question required students to explain how the biological approach could be used to investigate the difficulties of a 76-year-old man who had suddenly lost the ability to produce speech. Many students could offer some ways to investigate, eg, research his family history or use brain scans to look for damage. However, most simply talked about the possibility of damage in Broca's area being the cause of his difficulties without offering information about *how* the damage might be identified.

QUESTION 04.2

This question was generally well answered with just under half of students achieving 3 or 4 of the 6 marks available. Many were able to provide well-argued strengths and weaknesses of using the biological approach to understand behaviour and stronger students were able to explain why alternative approaches might offer better explanations for behaviour.

Weaker responses tended to offer list-like strengths and weaknesses which gain little credit. Students should be aware that offering lots of level 2 evaluation points will still only gain level 2 marks. Instead, they should offer one or two well developed points which link back to the theory/approach being evaluated. For example, to explain that the ability to develop drugs based on knowledge of neurotransmitters, such as dopamine, to treat schizophrenia is a strength because it reduces suffering and enables people with schizophrenia to function well in society.

QUESTION 05

This was a very well answered question with most achieving over half of the marks available. Students knew Pavlov's research very well and this enabled a number to achieve full marks for AO1. Stronger students could argue, for example, that Pavlov's research was well controlled because he was able to choose the tone of the bell and the number of repetitions involving pairing the neutral stimulus and the unconditioned stimulus and explain why this was a strength; this is effective evaluation. Once again however, there were many generic evaluation points, for example, about lab studies and replicability without referring to the details of the research studies conducted. This meant that many students could only achieve half of the AO3 marks available.

QUESTION 06

Most students were able to gain at least 2 marks of the 4 available for this question but only a small number were able to gain the full 4 marks. Many could apply their knowledge of free will and determinism to the scenario and explained Ben's standpoint very well in terms of hard/environmental determinism although most found it difficult to identify 'soft determinism' in Sarah's conversation.

QUESTIONS 07.1 and 07.2

Most students gained at least half marks for these questions showing that they understood the strengths and weaknesses of using a reductionist approach in psychology. However, whilst it seemed relatively straightforward to discuss a strength of using reductionism, it was clear that many found it more difficult to discuss a weakness, with most offering the idea that reductionism oversimplified behaviour without explaining why that was a weakness. Very few students understood that a taking a reductionist approach to study behaviour can result in a loss of meaning as the social context in which it occurs has been stripped away.

QUESTION 08

There was a pleasing response to this question with most able to describe the characteristics of science very well using key terminology. Stronger students were able to use topics they had learned on Paper one and/or Paper two to illustrate the ways in which a scientific approach has been used in psychology, eg, Asch being able to control the lengths of the lines he asked participants to judge so that his research could be replicated and Baillargeon being able to objectively measure the time infants spent looking at violation of expectation events. Again, stronger students could discuss why a scientific approach might be beneficial (eg, in terms of credibility and acceptance) and why some behaviours (eg, group behaviour) are best studied using non-scientific approach.

QUESTION 09

Most achieved the full 2 marks for this question by offering an accurate definition of social loafing. Once again this illustrates that nearly all students are preparing well in terms of knowledge and understanding.

QUESTION 10

This question was very well done with just over half of the students gaining 3 or 4 marks of the 4 AO2 marks available. The best answers went beyond the stem to explain that there are six basic emotions which are recognised universally and then offered some examples of these emotions. They then went on to explain that, since these are the same in all cultures, this ability must be genetic/inherited. A very pleasing response.

QUESTION 11

This was another well answered application question with well over half of all students gaining 3 or 4 marks of the 4 AO2 marks available. Most applied their knowledge well to suggest appropriate ideas for improving Chen's satisfaction at work. They used key terminology and relevant theories (such as job characteristics theory) to justify their choices. Weaker responses did not the stem effectively and offered suggestions based on goal-setting theory or hygiene factors. Regular practise identifying relevant theory from stems and descriptions of behaviour and then writing answers which link appropriate theory to explain the behaviour given or to make suggestions/recommendations would be a very useful exercise to help improve application skills.

QUESTION 12

It was pleasing to see that this extended-response question was attempted by most which suggests that students are managing their time better than in previous series. The theories surrounding workload and control had been well learned with most students able to offer accurate descriptions of Rotter's Locus of control theory and Karasek's JD-C model to show the effects of high workload and poor decision latitude on workplace stress. Many went on to describe the resulting effects on physical and mental health. Many were able to use Marmot's Whitehall studies to support their answers, either as AO1 or AO3, and did this very effectively. Some spent time describing the JD-R model which gained little credit, although others were able to use this very effectively as evaluation. However, as with other extended answer questions, some students struggled to gain marks beyond level 2 because they failed to develop their AO3 points into effective evaluation.

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